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Critical Approaches

Peace, International Organizations

Critical approaches to international relations are useful for prompting reevaluation of commonly held views and beliefs. Marxism and feminism, which afford critiques of the mainstream approaches, offer alternative ways to assess the role of international organizations in world affairs. Marxism and feminism can be seen as a critical reaction to the putative universality of realism and the ethnocentrism of liberalism. Like the mainstream approaches, critical approaches have philosophic origins and underlying assumptions that shape a particular kind of worldview.

Marxism

The Marxist approach to international relations makes several important contributions to understanding international relations and international organizations. First, and perhaps most importantly, Marxism provides a critique to the dominant approaches of realism and liberalism. Marxism challenges the realist assertion of the primacy of politics over economics and the liberal assertion that the expansion of the global market is beneficial to international peace and stability. Second, Marxism offers a comprehensive critique of capitalism as a mode of production. Marxist analyses of capitalism have identified issues that lead to genuine conflict within and between societies. Third, Marxism has articulated significantly different roles for international organizations. For Marxists, such organizations are neither great-power directorates nor relatively independent actors promoting the international public good; rather, they are tools of capitalism that undermine and exploit subordinate classes.

As an ideology, Marxism carries with it many negative connotations. Some people in the U.S. feel that American Marxists are traitors. Others see them as idealistic and misguided. Marxist-Leninist ideology is associated with brutal communist governments in the former Soviet Union, the former Eastern Bloc states, Cambodia, and China. Marxist ideology has also been at the heart of many social and political movements in the developing world, movements that were hostile to the U.S. and its interests. As a result, many tend to dismiss Marxist or Marxist-influenced explanations without considering whether or not they have any validity or provide any insight. Such a tendency is ill-advised because it narrows the scope of analysis. It is

analogous to dismissing liberal ideas about representation and democracy because the United States practiced slavery and Thomas Jefferson and George Washington owned slaves. Ideas can have merit even if their practice is offensive.

Marxist analyses have generated insights and explanations that are useful in understanding contemporary international relations. Marxist insights regarding the drawbacks of global capitalism have been used by former presidential candidates Ross Perot and Patrick Buchanan, neither of whom is considered a Marxist. Environmental groups and labor unions accept Marxist explanations without necessarily embracing Marxist ideology. Many in the developing world have a worldview that is a mixture of realism and Marxism. They are realists in that they are concerned about state sovereignty. After all, most developing states have experienced colonialism and have been formally independent only for the last couple of decades. Their relative weakness *vis à vis* the great powers has resulted in numerous interventions, and they understand the consequences of being a lesser power in an anarchical environment. Many in the developing world are also Marxist in that they are poor and economically disadvantaged. Their colonial history only reinforces their distrust of capitalism. In other words, many are on the short end of capitalism's stick. Their experience with capitalism is one of poverty, malnutrition, disease, and even violent death. Marxism enhances contemporary understandings of international relations and international organizations through its framework for understanding the relationship between economics and politics.

PHILOSOPHIC ROOTS OF MARXISM

Socrates (470–399 B.C.), the Athenian philosopher, may seem like an unlikely contributor to Marxist thought; however, he has influenced many different kinds of theorists, not to mention lawyers, through his method of inquiry. Known as Socratic inquiry, this method is a process for discovering truth by juxtaposing two contradictory ideas. By pitting a thesis against its antithesis, we reveal a new truth—a synthesis. The synthesis then becomes the new thesis, which is pitted against its antithesis, whereupon the process starts all over again. For Socrates, progress and knowledge are promoted by using this method of questioning alleged truths.

Socrates provides Marxism and other theories with a critical way to think about life. Progress is not always steady or even linear. It may occur in spurts, the result of a “two steps forward, three steps back” process. The first step in thinking critically is taking something that you believe to be true, say, “democracy allows most people to participate in politics,” then opposing it with its antithesis, “democracy excludes most people from politics.” Considerable evidence supports the antithesis. The history of U.S. suffrage (right to vote) suggests that participation was scarcely encouraged. The expansion of the electorate occurred over time according in the following order: exclusively adult white, male property owners; adult white males; adult black males; adult black males de facto disenfranchised; adult white women; adult white and black men and women; and eighteen-year-olds. In spite of the expansion of the electorate over the course of U.S. history, voting among eligible citizens has declined. A new truth, or synthesis, emerges: “Democracy as it is

practiced in the U.S. deters otherwise eligible citizens from effectively participating in politics." This new truth is then juxtaposed with its antithesis and the process starts over. This democracy example illustrates Socratic inquiry in a very simple fashion. Socratic inquiry represents a method of critical thinking that is often used in Marxist analyses of international relations.

Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel (1779–1831) was one of the many theorists influenced by the Socratic method. In *The Philosophy of Right*, Hegel uses a dialectic, a process quite similar to Socratic inquiry, to pit competing ideas about social and political relations against each other. Hegel departs from the liberal, social contract thinkers of his time in that he sees human beings as essentially social rather than economic creatures (Cahn 1997, 734). For Hegel, human beings were not merely individualistic and solitary creatures who enter into society merely to "truck, barter and trade." Rather, the highest form of freedom for individuals is participating in a politically organized community, or the state (Cahn 1997, 734). Hence, he distinguishes between what he terms "civil society," where humans behave in an individualistic manner and interact in a contractual sphere, and the "state," the politically organized community that promotes the collective good. Hegel's work suggests that the individual can be truly free and happy only as a part of the political community. Therefore, the health of the state is important in order for individuals to become self-actualized. The central difference between liberal thought and Hegel's communitarian ideas is that liberals place value on the individual. If the individual is happy, then so is society. Hegel places value on the society so that the individual can be happy. Hegel's contributions to the Marxist approach to international relations are his use of the dialectic and his emphasis on the environment/context in which individuals and groups interact.

Karl Marx (1818–1883) is, obviously, an intellectual precursor to the Marxist theoretical approach. Marx's central work, *The Communist Manifesto*, was written with his collaborator, friend, and benefactor, Friedrich Engels. In that work, they argue that history and progress can be seen dialectically as societies shift from one mode of production to another. A mode of production is simply the way goods and services are provided for a society. Slavery, feudalism, capitalism, and socialism are examples of ways in which goods and services can be produced. According to Marx, society is shaped by a mode of production and is organized around classes, which are based on their relationship to the means of production. The means of production are the resources that are needed to provide goods and services. For example, under feudalism, the economy was, in large part, agriculturally based. The means of production were the land and the tools needed to work on and farm the land. Feudal society was based on two principal classes, the aristocracy and the serfs. The aristocracy consisted of the lords and their families and they owned the land. The serfs worked the land in exchange for protection, food, and a place to live.

Marx sees economics, not ideas, as the driving force of society and politics. Marx is known to have said, "I have taken Hegel and stood him on his head." Rather than seeing the clash of ideas as the driving force of progress as Hegel did, Marx sees class conflict and the contradictions inherent in different modes of production as propelling progress forward. Thinking dialectically, Marx's thesis is the antithesis to Hegel's thesis. Marx argues that each mode of production contains within itself

the contradictions that will eventually lead to its collapse. Again, using feudalism as an example, we can see that its own contradictions undermined its dominance. These contradictions resulted from the clash between the social arrangements associated with feudalism coupled with technological advances. Emerging industrial technologies provided alternative ways for people to make a living and also created surpluses of goods. Under feudalism, land was passed down from father to the first-born son, so that estates could be kept intact. Second, third, and fourth sons usually had some money, but no inherited land. Once the father died, these sons often went off to the cities, investing in new technologies and starting new enterprises. Ironically, they became the foundation of a new class, the merchants. As these contradictions became too great, feudalism collapsed; and in its wake a new, dominant mode of production emerged—capitalism.

After feudalism's collapse, capitalism emerges, and with it, the nature of society fundamentally changes. New classes arise. The bourgeoisie are capitalists who own the factories, hire workers, and control most of the money. The proletariat are wage workers and managers who sell their labor for a salary. Society reorganizes itself around this new mode of production, and social and political institutions reflect the underlying economic order. Just as aristocracy reflects the interests of a dominant class under feudalism, democracy reflects the interests and needs of the bourgeoisie. Legitimacy to govern is no longer based on the idea of heredity. Rather, the liberal ideas that all men are created equal and have the right to political participation form the foundation of legitimate governance under capitalism. Democracy is based on the rule of law—law that was made by the majority rule of consenting men (initially, white men who owned property). Liberalism undermines the political authority of the aristocracy and legitimizes the new political structures, which favor the interests of the bourgeoisie.

Marx predicts that capitalism will also collapse under the weight of its own contradictions. Marx identifies many contradictions of capitalism that would impoverish the workers to such an extent that they would rise up and seize the means of production. Three of these are discussed below. Note, however, that Marx did not invent these contradictions. They were real problems—the pressing issues in the political economy of his day—which were also addressed by the likes of Malthus, Mill, and Ricardo. With the exception of Malthus (who was nothing if not "dismal"), these liberals are considerably more optimistic than Marx about the ability of the market to deal with the problems faced by capitalism. Marx described these problems as contradictions leading to market failure, and showing, at the very least, that capitalism is unstable and prone to crises.

The first problem is the tendency of the market toward the concentration of capital. Capitalists operating under market forces are driven toward greater and greater efficiency in the production of the goods and services. Competition and efficiency demand that capitalists reduce the cost of producing goods and services for markets. Inefficient and uncompetitive enterprises are driven out of market, which leads to oligopoly and monopoly and the accumulation of wealth in the hands of the few. The consequences of this contradiction are serious for both workers and consumers. Efficient production ultimately translates into reducing labor costs because labor accounts for the lion's share of production costs. The masses are

impoverished, owing to the resulting decline in wages and increased unemployment. When the market becomes dominated by a few firms (oligopoly) or one firm (monopoly), the remaining bourgeoisie can demand high prices. Once competition ceases to exist, so does capitalism.

A second contradiction of capitalism is the tendency toward overproduction. Liberals argue that the interaction of supply and demand, coupled with the price mechanism, prevents overproduction. Marx argues against this belief in the inherent equilibrium of the market, claiming that capitalism is prone to overproduction because greater efficiency allows capitalists to make more of the same good for the same or lesser cost. Demand for these goods also declines because the workers cannot easily afford them. As a result, the market is flooded with a surplus of goods and services.

A third contradiction is the falling rate of profit, which leads to oversavings on the part of capitalists. As capital accumulates, the rate of return on capital investments declines. Capitalists have less incentive to invest in productive enterprises and instead save their excess wealth. In other words, capitalist development is finite. Capital accumulation leads to a decline in investment returns until, finally, a point is reached when investment ceases. These contradictions lead to great disparities between rich and poor, the capitalists and the workers. The immiseration of the working class eventually leads to a socialist revolution, for the workers would have "nothing left to lose but their chains."

John A. Hobson (1858–1940), a British economist, indirectly provides an explanation as to why capitalism did not, in fact, collapse. His answer? Imperialism. Decidedly a non-Marxist, Hobson argues in *Imperialism* that overproduction, underconsumption, and oversavings force capitalists to seek new markets in order to sell their surplus goods and to find new outlets for investment. Hobson defines imperialism as "the endeavor of the great controllers of industry to broaden the channel for the flow of their surplus wealth by seeking foreign markets and foreign investments to take off the goods and capital they cannot sell or use at home" (Viotti and Kauppi 1993, 453). Hobson sees imperialism as a cause of war in that capitalist societies force their way into markets and even fight each other in order to gain access to new markets, cheap labor, and raw materials. Hobson might be considered a neomercantilist or economic nationalist in that he saw wars of imperial expansion as benefiting only certain segments of society (i.e., export capitalists, bankers) and not the nation as a whole.

Vladimir Ilyich Lenin (1870–1924) argues that the demise of capitalism, as predicted by Marx, was only postponed by imperialism. In *Imperialism: The Highest Stage of Capitalism*, Lenin argues that the contradictions of capitalism—overproduction, underconsumption, and oversavings—were temporarily resolved by the colonial expansion of capitalist states. "The acquisition of colonies had enabled the capitalist economies to dispose of their unconsumed goods, to acquire cheap resources and to vent their surplus capital" (Gilpin 1987, 38). Lenin argues that the expansion of capitalism through colonialism contributes to economic development internationally; however, that development is uneven. That is, capitalist powers develop unevenly, which leads to economic instability, political conflict, and war. Note that this explanation is quite similar to one type of realist explanation regarding the cause of war.

Realists argue that uneven growth rates cause shifts in the balance of power and that can lead to war. However, Lenin emphasizes the underlying economic causes of conflict whereas realists stress the political causes.

Antonio Gramsci (1891–1937), an Italian Marxist, contributes to the Marxist approach through his criticism of "economism"—the idea that economic and technological advancements account for change while politics is merely a reflection of the underlying economic order. According to Marx, capitalism is advancing toward economic collapse as the contradiction between the forces and the relations of production become greater. Gramsci maintains that the notion of economism is a defect in Marxist theory because it encourages the working class to remain passive, just waiting for the inevitable capitalist crisis (Simon 1982, 11). Gramsci conceives of society as a series of relations between different groups and classes. To understand the power of the bourgeoisie in capitalist society, it is necessary to bring politics back into the analysis.

According to Gramsci, politics is "the entire complex of practical and theoretical activities with which the ruling class not only justifies and maintains its dominance, but manages to win the active consent of those over whom it rules" (Hoare and Smit 1971, 114). The ruling class develops "hegemony," a concept initially conceived by Gramsci. Hegemony "has to do with the way one social group influences other groups, making certain compromises with them in order to gain their consent of its leadership in society as a whole" (Sassoon 1982, 13). This concept of hegemony is different from the one of sheer domination often employed by realists, liberals, and Marxists. Hegemony for Gramscian Marxists is the relation of consent to political and ideological leadership, not domination by force (Simon 1982, 11). This relation is based on compromise and incentive only to the extent of achieving deference. The core values of the ruling class, however, remain intact.

Gramsci provides another distinction between hegemony and dominance (Hoare and Smit 1971, 56–57). Domination results from the state's monopoly on the means of violence and its role as the final arbiter in all disputes. Hegemony, on the other hand, requires deference on the part of those who are led. Only weak states rely on force or domination to rule. Strong states rule through hegemony. A proletarian revolution would require an alternative hegemony that could displace the hegemonic relationship that already exists between the bourgeoisie and the masses.

Gramsci's contribution to Marxist thought (as well as to neoliberal and neorealist thinking) about international relations lies in the relevance of ideas to power. For Gramscian Marxists, the power of the bourgeoisie does not result solely from its control of the state and brute force. Any number of groups or coalition of groups can control the government. Power results from developing an ideology or hegemony where the interests of the dominant class or state are inextricably tied to the interests of subordinate classes, and workers buy into the system even though they are being exploited. The well-being of the firm is directly related to the well-being of the workers. Workers who question working conditions, seek to unionize, or try to improve wages are seen as threats not only by the bourgeoisie but also by other workers. Hence, labor leadership seeks reform within the system but refrains from trying to replace it. Social and political pressure is exerted on dissatisfied members

of subordinate classes to conform to existing bourgeois norms and values. Violence is employed only as a last resort.

Socrates, Hegel, Marx, Hobson, Lenin, and Gramsci—all have influenced the Marxist approach to international relations. Socrates contributes dialectical reasoning. Hegel adds the idea of the context in which economic, social, and political relations take place. Marx provides an alternative view regarding class formation and identifies contradictions that threaten the stability of capitalism. Hobson and Lenin bring to the fore the economic causes and the political consequences of colonialism. Gramsci shows how ideas relate to power and the dominance of one class by another with their active consent. These influences are evident in the following section detailing the assumptions of the contemporary Marxist theoretical approach to understanding international politics and international organizations.

CONTEMPORARY MARXISM

The Marxist approach to international relations consists of many different perspectives. These perspectives are distinguished by their emphases on economically determined classes, the international division of labor, and economic forces as critical for understanding international relations. Like realism and liberalism, Marxism as a theoretical approach rests on several underlying assumptions. The first assumption is that global capitalism determines the position and behavior of actors in international affairs. For the Marxist, the defining characteristic of the international system is not the anarchy of realism or the interdependence of liberalism. Capitalism as a global mode of production is the systemic feature that explains the dynamics of international relations. The world capitalist economic system imposes constraints on actors and motivates their behavior. Private property, the profit motive, and the exigencies of the market affect economic actors and the societies in which they operate.

The assumption that capitalism as a global mode of production matters is not particularly divergent from realist and liberal systemic assumptions. The neorealist sees participation in the global economy as the key to great-power status. Having power enables states to pursue national security and interests under conditions of anarchy. The global economy currently happens to be capitalist. The liberal argues that interdependence results from interaction between private individuals in the market. The Marxist lens simply shifts the focus slightly and emphasizes global capitalism.

The second assumption of the Marxist approach is that the principal unit of analysis is economic class. Marxists see the actors in international relations as being defined by economic class. International relations are driven by economic production; therefore, the principal actors are distinguished by their role in the global production of goods and services. Two of the most prominent Marxist theories, dependency theory and modern world system theory, vary slightly regarding the role of class. Dependency theorists tend to take a traditional Marxist view on class and apply it to the international system (e.g., Packenham 1992; Valenzuela and Valenzuela 1978; Cardoso and Faletto 1979; Amin 1977; Evans 1979). These theorists

seek to explain why economic development has not occurred in many Third World states, particularly those in Latin America. They argue that neocolonialism, capitalist expansion, and the creation of grossly asymmetrical interdependent relationships are responsible for under- and maldevelopment in the Third World.

Dependency theorists explain that underdevelopment in the Third World must be understood in historical context. The majority of Third World states were once colonies of the Western capitalist powers, serving both as captive markets and as sources of raw material and cheap labor. After decolonization, the international bourgeoisie continued to control these newly independent states through more subtle means. Whereas colonialism refers to territorial domination by force, neocolonialism refers to the nonterritorial, economic controls exercised by capitalist states over the developing world.

Neocolonialism represents a more sophisticated exploitation. The military conquest and the subjugation of a population are expensive endeavors. Colonial powers have to administer the affairs of the colonies, thus incurring costs. Recall Hobson's critique of imperialism, that it was a drain on state resources and benefited only those earning profits from international economic transactions. Under neocolonialism, newly formed Third World states possess sovereignty in legal principle; in practice, however, the colonial powers retain *de facto* control over the raw material, market, and labor. Within the Third World itself, the ruling class, composed largely of willing collaborators who helped administer the colonies, retained control after decolonization. Termed the *comprador* class by dependency theorists, this group of elites became a domestic bourgeoisie whose role was to aid in the exploitation of their own society by international and transnational capitalists (Viotti and Kauppi 1993, 458). The interests of the *comprador* class are tied to the interests of global capitalism, not to the development and progress of their own societies.

Dependency theorists analyze the impact of capitalism on developing states; hence it's fair to say that they consider states as important in international relations. Nevertheless, they see the state as a reflection of the dominant class interests, the domestic bourgeoisie. The state is subordinated to the bourgeois class that controls it. Seen in its best light, the state reproduces the necessary elements of capitalism (infrastructure, an educated workforce, and so on) and also enforces contracts and property rights. At worst, the state is the "executive committee of the bourgeoisie," which uses the state's coercive authority to further its own interests and exploit subordinate classes.

Modern world system theorists take a similar state-centric approach to international relations, viewing the system as one organized around nation-states. But they see these states as *classes* of states—each class being determined by a state's place in the international division of labor in a world capitalist system. Immanuel Wallerstein (1980) identifies three such classes, categorizing them as core, periphery, and semiperiphery. The core consists of industrialized states, which provide capital to the global economy, as well as highly skilled and well paid labor. The periphery provides inexpensive, unskilled labor and raw materials. The semiperiphery represents the newly industrializing countries, which provide cheap skilled and semiskilled labor to the global economy. Put another way, the core represents the global bourgeoisie while the periphery and semiperiphery represent the global proletariat.

The systematic exploitation of the periphery by the core has occurred over the last five hundred years, although the character of the exploitation has changed significantly. From around 1500 until 1945, core exploitation of the periphery came in the form of (territorial) colonialism. After 1945 and until 1980, the pattern of exploitation shifted from territorial to economic means. Instead of forcibly extracting raw materials using cheap unskilled labor for use in the core, the core either leased the resources or purchased them cheaply on the open market. These resources were brought to the core for the production of highly valued manufactured goods. The manufactured goods were sold in the core and any surplus was exported to the periphery for sale.

This pattern of exploitation leads to bad *terms of trade*, meaning the ratio of the value of imports to the value of exports. Ideally, these values should be equal. But if the value of imports exceeds the value of exports, a state loses wealth because it must pay for imported goods with foreign currency—currency it can get only by borrowing or earning it through the export of its goods. Under bad terms of trade not enough wealth and capital can be accumulated to form the critical mass necessary for spurring sustained economic growth. Thus, bad terms of trade can be quite detrimental to development. Since the 1980s, the rapid globalization of production has changed the pattern of exploitation again. The periphery still provides raw materials and unskilled labor; however, the semiperiphery, which includes newly industrializing countries (NICs) such as Malaysia, Mexico, Brazil, and Hong Kong, has emerged as an intermediary in the production process. The semiperiphery serves two key purposes for global capitalism. First, it serves as a safety valve when wages become too high in the core. Second, it is the locus for manufacturing as the core economies shift to more service-oriented enterprises such as banking, insurance, and telecommunications.

The post-1980s pattern of capitalist exploitation has shifted economic analysis away from conceptualizing core/periphery/semiperiphery relations as state-based relationships—say, for example, the idea that France as a core state benefits from the economic exploitation of Algeria, a periphery state. Global production activities have increased the utility of using economic classes as a unit of analysis. Increasingly, workers throughout the core are experiencing either high unemployment or declining real wages. Core/periphery/semiperiphery relations can be characterized by an international bourgeoisie (which just happens to be French or British or American) that benefits at the expense of workers everywhere.

Modern world system theory and dependency theory both see class and the state as part and parcel of each other. Dependency theorists tend to view the state as a reflection of the dominant economic class. Modern world system theorists view the state and the nation-state system as necessary for capitalist accumulation. “A balance of power among a number of leading states inhibits the development of a single overarching political authority that could subvert international production and exchange” (Crane and Amawi 1997, 142). The capitalist accumulation process, of course, benefits the international bourgeoisie.

These Marxist views of the state contrast with the realist and liberal views of the state and the nature of other kinds of actors in international relations. Realists see the state as a unitary, rational actor seeking to maximize the national interest. Liberals

tend to see the state as a disaggregated entity composed of a congeries of competing interests that results in the maximization of individual welfare. Marxists also see the state as a disaggregated entity composed of classes. In the Marxist worldview, however, one class, the bourgeoisie, usually dominates the government.

A third assumption of the Marxist theoretical approach is that international relations is essentially conflictual. Exploitation breeds conflict within and between societies. Capitalism fosters violence as well as economic, social, and political inequality. For Marxists, as long as capitalism (or any other mode of production based on exploitation) dominates international economics, international conflict will continue. International conflict manifests itself in the form of interstate wars, terrorism, and intrastate violence such as government repression or civil war. In an era of global production and the interdependence it breeds, violence within a society often has international and global causes and implications.

A fourth, related assumption is that economic, not political or strategic, factors are most important to understanding international affairs. Issues that appear to be geostrategic and military in nature are rooted in capitalist accumulation and exploitation. After all, military capability and other elements of power are directly related to economic capability. Wars between great and lesser powers have occurred because of colonialism. In the post-colonial period, wars have occurred because of access to markets, labor, and resources. Hegemonic or great-power wars such as World Wars I and II were as much about how the world was going to produce things as about who would be the world leader. The Cold War was not the product of the Soviet Union's posing a serious military threat to the West. Rather, it was the result of the U.S. quest for an economic empire (Kolko and Kolko 1972). The Marxist theoretical framework provides an alternative mechanism for analyzing international relations. Its focus on global capitalism, economic classes, conflict, and economic motivations provides a different perspective regarding the nature of governance in the twentieth century.

MARXISM AND THE NATURE OF INTERNATIONAL ORGANIZATIONS

Like many liberals and realists, Marxists argue that international organizations are created through hegemony. However, traditional Marxists and Gramscian Marxists have diverging notions of hegemony, notions that lead them to different conclusions regarding the nature of international organizations. Traditional Marxists tend to equate hegemony with military and economic dominance. International organizations are created, then imposed on the rest of the world. International organizations reinforce and promote the capitalist mode of production whereby the dominant position of the core and the subordinate positions of the semiperiphery and periphery are institutionalized.

International organizations are mechanisms of capitalist domination and exploitation. The international order established by the U.S. after World War II was a capitalist system in which the U.S. had a competitive advantage in industrial production. An international system based on liberal (capitalist) economic principles